

Midlands State University

Proposal Writing

February 26, 2025

Research Proposal

Project

A research proposal provides clear communication of your ideas and questions to your prospective supervisor, a clear indication of your proposed contribution to the body of knowledge, and brief details on what has been done on the subject to date and how you propose to proceed with your study.

Project

- It sells your proposed research without being dishonest about what can and cannot be achieved.
- Care must be taken to demonstrate an academic attitude of inquiry.
- Do not oversell your ideas (be realistic).
- Use academic language and stay focused on key issues.
- Provide key facts (hard facts not unsubstantiated claims and stories) in your background of study

Project Proposal

Project

“You identify your origin, select a destination, and plot the shortest distance between the two points.” (Richard M. White)

Topic or project focus identification

- Choose a project focus that you are particularly interested in.
- Discuss your project ideas with your friends or lecturers or experts or those who might be interested in your ideas.
- Write down your ideas.

Sources

- Personal interest
- Information or observation
- Practical problems
- Readings

Basic Questions

- Think of the following basic questions:
- **WHAT**: what is the phenomenon? What are the issues?
- **WHO**: who is affected by the issue? Who will benefit from the project?
- **WHERE**: are there particular places affected by the problem? At what level?
- **WHEN**: is the project focus a current one?
- **HOW**: how are you going to explore it?

Components

- A project proposal outlines
- **WHAT** you would like to do,
- **WHY** you do it and
- **HOW** you do it.

Structure of a proposal

- Cover page
- Introduction
- Background to the study
- Problem statement
- Research Questions
- Research Objectives
- Expected Outcomes
- Justification of the study
- Scope of the study
- Assumptions of the study
- Literature review
- Research Methodology
- Limitations to the study
- Definition of key terms
- Timeline
- Budget
- Summary

- Cover page: must provide the following details
- University
- Faculty
- Department
- Proposed Topic
- Student Name and Reg. Number
- Date (e.g. April 2015)
- City and Country (e.g. Gweru, Zimbabwe)

Introduction

Introduces the study just like any other introduction

Background to the study

- Provides relevant facts on the subject of the proposed study .
- Facts must be presented preferably in graphical form (do not overuse graphs though) to depict the trend in the development of the problem giving rise to the proposed research.
- Readers must start to have an idea about the magnitude and state of the problem based on the background.
- The research gap must come out clearly without you having to explain yourself.
- Background facts must provide immediate justification for the study

Statement of the problem

- Problem statement establishes the direction of your project.
- It is the heart of your proposed project.
- After reading your problem statement, the reader should know **WHAT** and **WHY** you are doing the project.

In general,

- a problem statement will:
 - ➊ highlight the negative points of the current situation,
 - ➋ explain why this matters and
 - ➌ communicate a solution.
- It also serves as a great communication tool, helping to get buy-in and support from others.

Problem Statement

Basic parts

- A potential problem statement consists of four basic parts:
 - 1 The reality: normally negative points
 - 2 The consequences
 - 3 Ideal: Proposed solution
 - 4 Purpose of project proposal

Problem Statement Example

Example

“Crime rate in City A has been increasing in the past few years although the government has come up with many programs and strategies intended to fight crime. Maintaining the same practice would mean that government resources will be wasted while crime cannot be prevented. Recent studies suggest that the use of technology is one of the best ways to prevent crime. This project intends to equip City A with the latest technology for crime prevention.”

Objectives

- These are like the specific aims or goals of your research.
- Identify the 'Main Objective' of the study and the 'Sub-Objectives' of the study.
- The main objective is like the general purpose of your study and sub-objectives are the specific tasks which when completed allow you to achieve the main objective.
- Thus there must be a logical link between the specific objectives and the main objective.
- Use action-oriented words in stating objectives e.g. 'To examine, To describe, To analyze etc.'

Objectives

Objectives must be:

- Specific
- Measurable
- Achievable
- Realistic
- Time-bound

Research Questions

- Consider these questions as 'sub-problems'.
- Finding answers to the research questions must allow you to solve the research problem.
- Research questions are normally derived from the 'specific research objectives'.
- Research questions direct you to the relevant data for the research (data requirements)

Justification of the Study

Justification

- This section highlights the contribution of your proposed study to the existing stock of knowledge.
- If you failed to identify a genuine research gap in your problem statement you cannot do well here either.
- Justification of your study relies heavily on the facts you have presented in the background.
- You may also want to pay attention to who is likely to find your research useful and how the successful conduct of the study would benefit them, e.g. policy makers may get insights on the success of past policies, the academic community may get insights on the empirical success of models etc.
- Do not confuse the significance of the subject you are studying with the significance of your proposed study! A study on an important subject may be insignificant because its line of enquiry lacks adequate depth or its approach is outdated.

Scope of the study

Scope of the study

- Here you are setting boundaries for your study to ensure focus and prevent ambiguities in interpretation of your research findings, conclusions and recommendations.
- You are confining the supervisor to what you intend to cover while helping him/her know what the study will not cover.
- Defining the scope clearly will allow your supervisor to determine if your proposed study will have the depth and breadth appropriate for your level of study.
- Your scope must incorporate the following 5 components:
 - Geographical scope
 - Entity scope
 - Conceptual scope
 - Parametric scope
 - Temporal scope

Assumptions of the study

Assumptions

- Assumptions are statements that are taken to be true and are not subject to verification by way of empirical evidence (unlike hypotheses).
- They are needed for convenience of analysis, noting that in the social sciences it is not ordinarily possible to conduct experiments while holding other influences constant.
- Assumptions allow us to pursue a few lines of enquiry without having to worry about extraneous influences on our output variables.
- Assumptions must not be confused with hopes, wishes and expectations. E.g. it is not appropriate to assume that respondents will complete questionnaires or that you will access the required data. These are your hopes and wishes for the future and to some extent relate to issues within your control.
- State only the major assumptions of the study and leave out trivialities

Literature Review

- Here you give a brief review of the main ideas in the literature based on a preliminary literature search.
- This section must provide snippets of the controversies on the subject and highlight the theoretical or empirical gap as necessary.
- Demonstrate to your supervisor that other scholars have shown interest in the subject and continue to do so.
- Your supervisor will also want some evidence of preliminary consultation of latest works by leading scholars in the field. This shows your awareness of the subject and your interest therein.
- Be selective in your choice of literature based on: 1. Relevance to the topic, 2. Currency, and 3. Authority (both source and author).

Methodology

- Here you want to show your prospective supervisor that you know how to conduct the study by proposing a preliminary scheme for conducting the study.
- Highlight the following:
 - Research design:-relates to the broad plan you propose to adopt in actually executing tasks essential to the study e.g. Are you going to conduct experiments from which you obtain data for use in the study or you are going to conduct a survey where you seek general data from the broader community of people closer to the problem or you are going to focus on a specific part of the community that has potential to yield more detailed insights?
 - Sampling design:-how are you going to decide on who will be a participant in the study?
 - Data sources and collection procedure:-where will you get the data and how?
 - Data analysis and Presentation:-how will you process, present and interpret the data and findings?

Limitations to the study

Limitations to the study

- What methodological constraints do you foresee and how do you plan to manage them?
- Stick to genuine methodological constraints which are normally an inherent part of research of the type you propose; time, money, and skill are not permissible constraints since it is expected that you only choose to work on a topic because you have enough time, resources and skill to complete the study successfully.
- Do not sound defeated here; remember you want to show not only that you **KNOW** what you want to do but also that you **CAN DO** it!

Definition of key terms

Here you give the meanings of the specialized terms used in the proposal that may either have more than one meaning or whose meaning in the context of the proposed study differ from their ordinary meaning.

Time budget

Show your supervisor how much time you propose to spend on each task so that he helps you revise your plan and also for monitoring of progress.

Summary

Close by briefly going over what the proposal has covered.

References

References

Include all the references used in your study and be consistent with the referencing style.